

The Work-From-Home Scam Checklist

Nine red flags, straight from the FTC playbook. If you spot one, slow down.

The one rule that beats them all:

A real job pays you. You never pay it.



1. Asks you to pay upfront

HIGH

The number one FTC red flag. A real job pays you. Fees for a starter kit, training, software, or to hold a spot almost always mean a scam.



2. Earn by recruiting others

HIGH

Income that comes from signing up other people (a downline) instead of selling a real product is the core of an MLM or pyramid scheme.



3. Unrealistic income claims

HIGH

Big specific numbers for little work (\$5k a week from your phone) are bait. Honest opportunities give ranges and admit it takes time.



4. Overpayment or odd payment

HIGH

Being sent a check to deposit then asked to send part back is classic fraud. So is being paid or asked to pay in gift cards, wire, or crypto.



5. Wants sensitive info early

HIGH

Bank login, full SSN, or a photo of your ID before any real hiring step is an identity-theft setup. Real onboarding asks later, through secure systems.



6. Reshipping or package handling

HIGH

Receiving and reshipping packages, or processing payments through your own account, makes you a money or goods mule. A crime even if you did not know.

A few more, then what to do

Red flags 7 to 9, plus the safe next move.



7. Vague system, no real product

MEDIUM

If they cannot plainly say what you would do or sell, and lean on a proven system, secret method, or blueprint, there is usually nothing real underneath.



8. Pressure and false urgency

MEDIUM

Real employers do not rush you. Only a few spots, today only, and message me ASAP are designed to stop you from thinking it through.



9. Pushes you off-platform fast

MEDIUM

Being moved immediately to WhatsApp or Telegram, or hired with no interview, is how scammers avoid oversight.

If something trips a flag

- Stop. Do not pay, deposit a check, or share bank or ID details.
- Paste the message into the free Scam Smell Test at firstpaycheck.co.
- Search the company name plus the word scam before you reply.
- When in doubt, walk away. A real opportunity will still be there tomorrow.